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Toh 43 · Derge Kangyur

Toh 43 is a sutra of the Kangyur belonging to the early scriptural narrative class, here concluding with the account of the sun and moon deities and the demon Rahu—known in Tibetan as the "Sutra of the Moon" (Zla ba'i mdo), corresponding to a Sanskrit title such as Candra Sūtra. The passage preserved here depicts Rahu, the seizer who grasps the heavenly bodies, declaring that upon hearing the Buddha's verses he dare not withhold the moon, for fear that his head would split into seven pieces and he would find no ease in his existence. This brief but vivid episode illustrates the Buddha's power to command even cosmic and demonic forces through the simple utterance of verses of truth, a theme recurring in several short sutras of this type preserved in the Kangyur. As Toh 43, it stands among the discourses attributed directly to the Buddha, valued both for its doctrinal content on the protective power of the Dharma and for its place within the broader cycle of texts concerning celestial bodies and their guardian deities.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.